Tennessee Mandatory Attendance Law

What to Do When a Student Disappears: Legal Obligations, Best Practices, and Equity Considerations

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Executive Summary

When a student stops showing up to school and the family has traveled to Mexico, Tennessee school administrators face a situation that sits at the intersection of compulsory attendance law, federal civil rights protections, immigration policy, cultural sensitivity, and practical district operations. This report provides a comprehensive guide to navigating that situation legally, ethically, and effectively.

Tennessee law (TCA 49-6-3001 et seq.) requires attendance for all children ages 6-17. After 5 unexcused absences, districts must implement progressive truancy interventions including a parent conference, an attendance contract, and follow-up meetings. After 10 consecutive unexcused absences, a student meets the statutory definition of "withdrawal" under TCA 49-6-3017. However, withdrawal does not end the district's obligations: the compulsory attendance law still applies to school-age children, and the progressive truancy plan must be followed before any court referral.

Federal law adds critical protections. Under Plyler v. Doe (1982), schools cannot deny enrollment or take actions that "chill" immigrant families' access to education, regardless of immigration status. ESSA requires chronic absenteeism tracking as an accountability metric. Title III provides specific protections and funding for immigrant students. FERPA prohibits sharing student information with immigration authorities without consent. In the current immigration enforcement climate, where ICE raids have been linked to a 22% increase in student absences nationally (PNAS, 2025), districts must be especially careful that truancy enforcement does not become a mechanism that drives families further away from schools.

The research is clear: punitive approaches to truancy are largely ineffective and often counterproductive, particularly for immigrant families. The strongest evidence supports a "support first, enforce last" model with tiered interventions, bilingual family outreach, culturally responsive communication, and a focus on addressing root causes rather than assigning blame. For a small district like Greeneville City Schools, the recommended approach is to (1) document all contact attempts, (2) engage bilingual support if needed, (3) follow the progressive truancy plan, (4) prepare a welcoming re-engagement plan for the student's return, and (5) avoid any action that could be perceived as targeting the family based on national origin or immigration status.

1. Definition and Background

1.1 Compulsory Attendance in the United States

Every U.S. state has a compulsory attendance law, though the specifics vary considerably. Most states require attendance between ages 5-6 and 16-18. The seminal economic research by Angrist and Krueger (1991) demonstrated that compulsory attendance laws have measurable effects on schooling and earnings: individuals subject to these laws complete approximately 10% more years of education, with about 25% of potential dropouts staying in school because of the laws. Each additional year of compulsory schooling produces a 7.3-8.2% increase in weekly adult income.

1.2 Key Definitions

- **Chronic Absenteeism:** Missing 10% or more of instructional days (typically 18+ days per year). Counts all absences, both excused and unexcused.
- **Truancy:** Accumulating unexcused absences beyond the threshold set by state law. In Tennessee, 5 unexcused absences triggers truancy interventions.
- **Educational Neglect:** Failure of a parent or guardian to ensure a child attends school as required by compulsory attendance law. A Class C misdemeanor in Tennessee.
- **Withdrawal (TN definition):** More than 10 consecutive or 15 total unexcused absences in a single semester under TCA 49-6-3017.

1.3 The Post-COVID Context

Chronic absenteeism peaked at 28.5% nationally in 2022, a 91% increase from pre-pandemic levels, adding 6.5 million newly chronically absent students (AEI, 2024). As of 2024-25, the rate has declined to approximately 23% but remains roughly 50% higher than pre-pandemic baselines (RAND, 2025). Tennessee's chronic absenteeism rate was 20% in 2022-23, up from 13% pre-pandemic. The percentage of students chronically absent for three consecutive years tripled from 2.4% to 7.8% nationally (Brookings, 2024).

Metric	Pre-Pandemic	Peak (2021-22)	Current (2024-25)
National chronic absence rate	~15%	28.5%	~23%
Tennessee chronic absence rate	13%	20%	~16-23%
Students chronically absent 3+ years	2.4%	--	7.8%

This context matters because the student in question is one of many absent students districts are managing simultaneously. Systems and protocols designed for rare cases must now handle a much larger volume.

2. Evidence of Effectiveness: What Works for Attendance

2.1 Academic Impact of Absenteeism

The research base on the academic consequences of absenteeism is robust. Balfanz and Byrnes (2012) at Johns Hopkins found that achievement, especially in math, is "very sensitive to attendance" and that absence of even two weeks during one school year matters measurably. Gottfried (2014) found chronic absenteeism in kindergarten was associated with lower reading and math achievement, reduced educational engagement, and decreased social engagement. Liu et al. (2022, PNAS) found that schools averaging only 5 days absent typically have 80%+ proficiency in Math and ELA, but an increase to 10 days average is associated with proficiency dropping below 20%. Students chronically absent in preschool through first grade who fail to reach grade-level reading by third grade are 4 times more likely to drop out of high school. For every standard deviation increase in attendance, academic performance increases by approximately 0.08 SD, with larger effects for low-performing students.

2.2 Effective Interventions

Heyne et al. (2020), in a meta-analysis of 22 controlled intervention studies, found small but positive overall effects on attendance outcomes for mentoring, family involvement initiatives, school counseling, incentive programs, school-based healthcare, and police partnership strategies. The most effective truancy strategies operate at multiple levels: individual (mentoring, counseling), school (positive climate, engaging instruction), and community (after-school programs, wraparound services).

Evidence-based interventions ranked by strength of evidence:

Intervention	Evidence Level	Key Finding
Nudge letters to parents	Strong (RCT)	Reduced chronic absenteeism by 10-15% across 12 districts
Success Mentors	Strong	Students gained ~2 additional weeks of schooling per year
LEAP Home Visits	Strong	7-15 percentage point attendance increase
Attendance incentives	Moderate	Improved attendance from 82.4% to 92%
Redesigned truancy letters	Strong (RCT)	40% more effective than standard punitive letters
Community schools model	Moderate-Strong	Sustained attendance gains through wraparound services
Truancy court referral	Weak/Mixed	Limited effectiveness; may damage family-school

		relationship

2.3 What Does Not Work

The research is clear that punitive measures are largely ineffective and sometimes counterproductive. Harsh sanctions such as out-of-home placement, denial of welfare benefits, or sending police to homes are more likely to increase truancy than reduce it (OJJDP Truancy Prevention Literature Review). The Wisconsin DPI review and others confirm that disciplinary approaches to truancy are "highly ineffective." Schools that use suspension as punishment for truancy effectively "push out" students; one study found 70% of suspended students were chronically truant in the 6 months before suspension. California enacted changes in 2025 removing jail and fine penalties tied to chronic truancy, with legislators stating that fining or imprisoning parents "failed to deliver the education or support children needed."

3. Federal and State Policy Context

3.1 Federal Requirements

ESSA and Chronic Absenteeism

The Every Student Succeeds Act (ESSA) requires states to include a non-academic measure of school quality. At least 36 states and Washington, D.C. have adopted chronic absenteeism as this indicator. Tennessee uses chronic absenteeism as part of the COSI (Conditions of Student Improvement) accountability metric. Schools identified for Comprehensive Support and Improvement (CSI) or Targeted Support and Improvement (TSI) may be flagged in part due to chronic absenteeism rates.

Plyler v. Doe (1982)

The U.S. Supreme Court ruled that denying undocumented children access to free public K-12 education violates the Equal Protection Clause. Under Plyler, schools may NOT:

- Deny admission based on immigration status
- Treat students differently to determine residency
- Engage in practices that "chill" the right of access to school
- Require disclosure of immigration status
- Require Social Security numbers from all students

This is directly relevant: any truancy enforcement action that could expose or inquire about a family's immigration status, or that creates a chilling effect on the family's willingness to re-enroll, could run afoul of Plyler principles.

Immigration Enforcement and Schools (2025 Policy Change)

On January 21, 2025, the Department of Homeland Security rescinded the Biden-era "sensitive locations" policy that had prevented immigration enforcement at schools since 2011. Research published in PNAS (2025) found that local immigration raids in early 2025 coincided with a 22% increase in daily student absences, with particularly large increases among the youngest students. Half of all educators surveyed who work with immigrant families reported students expressing fear or anxiety. Major school districts experienced significant enrollment drops: Los Angeles and Miami-Dade both saw 4% decreases.

For this scenario, aggressive truancy enforcement that involves court systems could trigger immigration fears, even if the family has legal status. The involvement of government agencies (courts, DCS) may cause families to disengage entirely rather than risk exposure.

IDEA Protections

If the absent student has an IEP or 504 plan, additional protections apply. The district must determine whether absences are a manifestation of the student's disability before imposing consequences. IDEA's Child Find provision requires districts to identify and evaluate all children with disabilities within their jurisdiction, including those not currently attending school. A student who has stopped attending may need evaluation.

Title III: English Learners and Immigrant Students

Title III provides specific subgrants for districts experiencing increases in immigrant enrollment. The U.S. Department of Education has interpreted Plyler to mean schools must not engage in "practices that may chill or discourage the participation, or lead to the exclusion, of students based on their or their parents' or guardians' actual or perceived citizenship or immigration status." Aggressive truancy enforcement against immigrant families could be viewed as a chilling practice.

FERPA Protections

The Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) prohibits schools from disclosing personally identifiable information from student records without parental consent. Districts can and should adopt policies explicitly prohibiting the sharing of immigration-related information with enforcement authorities.

McKinney-Vento Act

If the family's housing situation changes upon return (e.g., doubled up with relatives, no fixed address), McKinney-Vento protections may apply. Homeless children must be enrolled immediately, even without typical documentation. Accrued absences cannot be used to deny re-enrollment.

3.2 Tennessee Law: Step-by-Step

Tennessee's compulsory attendance framework is found in TCA 49-6-3001 through 49-6-3017. Here is the complete statutory framework a district must follow:

Threshold	Statute	Required Action
Start of school year	TCA 49-6-3007	Principal gives written notice to all parents about attendance requirements
3 unexcused absences	TCA 49-6-3007	May serve written notice to parent that attendance is required by law
5 unexcused absences	TCA 49-6-3007, 3009	MUST implement Tier 2: conference, attendance contract, follow-up meetings, individualized assessment
Continued absences	TCA 49-6-3009	Tier 3: intensive case management, community services, alternative programs
After all tiers fail	TCA 49-6-3009	Director of schools may refer to juvenile court (must certify interventions were attempted)

10 consecutive unexcused	TCA 49-6-3017	Meets statutory definition of "withdrawal"; driver's license implications for minors
15 total unexcused (semester)	TCA 49-6-3017	Also meets "withdrawal" definition

The Progressive Truancy Plan

Tennessee law requires every LEA to adopt a board-approved progressive truancy plan. The attendance supervisor devises the plan under the director of schools' direction. Key requirements:

- **Design:** The plan must include tiers of intervention that minimize the need for juvenile court referrals.
- **Prohibition:** In-school or out-of-school suspension must NOT be used as part of the truancy plan.
- **Contract:** The Tier 2 attendance contract must include specific expectations, the contract period, penalties for additional absences, and signatures from student, parent, and school representative.
- **Court Certification:** Before filing a truancy petition, the school must certify that progressive interventions were applied and failed to meaningfully address attendance.

Excused vs. Unexcused Absences

There is no comprehensive state definition of excused absences. Each district determines its own policy under SBE Policy 4.100. Generally, excused absences include illness, death in the family, and absences covered by a parent note, but districts set their own limits on parent notes. This means the classification of absences for a student who traveled to Mexico depends entirely on local district policy. If the family did not communicate in advance and the district policy does not provide for extended travel absences, these days will accumulate as unexcused absences.

Educational Neglect and DCS

Violation of compulsory attendance constitutes educational neglect under TCA 49-6-3009, a Class C misdemeanor. Each day's unlawful absence constitutes a separate offense. A DCS referral is appropriate when non-attendance is part of a broader pattern of neglect (basic needs not met, abandonment, safety concerns), but the typical pathway for truancy alone is through juvenile court after the progressive plan has been exhausted.

Juvenile Court Process

If a student with 5+ unexcused absences is referred to and adjudicated unruly by juvenile court, the judge may assess a fine of up to $50 against the parent or order up to 5 hours of community service. The judge deals with each case as determined to be in the best interest of the student. The petition must set forth the facts that bring the child within the court's jurisdiction.

TISA Funding Implications

Tennessee uses ADM (Average Daily Membership), an enrollment-based funding model. Daily absences do not directly reduce the ADM count. However, a student who is withdrawn or dropped stops being counted in ADM for subsequent reporting periods, reducing the district's overall funding. The 2025-26 TISA base per-pupil allocation averages $9,810.54. For a district of ~2,500 students, if chronic absenteeism drives even 1% to withdraw, that is approximately $245,000 in lost TISA revenue.

4. What Works: Implementation Models

4.1 The Withdraw-and-Re-Enroll Model

Many districts handle extended absences through a withdraw-and-re-enroll process. Students missing 10-15 consecutive days while out of the area are dis-enrolled, then re-registered upon return. This approach protects the district's attendance data and funding formulas, avoids accumulating unexcused absences on the student's record, and allows a clean re-start with an attendance contract upon return. Examples include Palo Alto USD (10 days), Prince William County (15 days), and Prince George's County (10 days).

4.2 Bilingual Family Engagement

The research consistently identifies language and cultural barriers as primary obstacles to attendance for immigrant families. Effective strategies include:

- Hiring bilingual/bicultural parent liaisons to bridge communication gaps
- Providing all school communications and meeting interpretation in the family's language
- Hosting parent-teacher meetings with flexible scheduling (evenings, weekends)
- Designating a single point of contact for each family to build trust over time
- Conducting home visits when families cannot be reached by phone or email

Livingston Union School District in California, a small district with a significant Latino population, lowered chronic absenteeism from 18.3% to 14.2% by investing in school counselors and bilingual, family-centered outreach.

4.3 Re-Engagement After Extended Absence

When a student returns from an extended absence, the research recommends:

- Designate one point of contact (homeroom teacher or counselor) to coordinate
- Proactively offer differentiated assignments and extended deadlines
- Use asynchronous digital tools so students can catch up at their own pace
- Conduct a root cause analysis to understand "why" behind the absence
- Maintain active communication with the family
- Create a welcoming, trauma-informed environment, framing re-engagement as reconnection, not punishment
- Involve counselors trained to balance emotional and academic needs

4.4 Small District Success Stories

Several small and rural districts have achieved significant results:

- **Mountain Valley Education Consortium (CA):** Multiple elementary districts in Shasta County, CA hired two chronic absenteeism coordinators using Community Schools grant funding. Coordinators monitored attendance daily and contacted families to identify barriers.

- **Coalinga-Huron USD (CA):** Reduced chronic absenteeism for students experiencing homelessness by 10.6 percentage points in a single year through weekly team huddles and county-level coordination.
- **Crow-Applegate-Lorane SD (OR):** Achieved low chronic absenteeism (15.2%) by prioritizing relationship-based approaches over punitive measures.

Common success factors across small districts: daily attendance monitoring with same-day family contact, phone calls and texts for every unexcused absence, home visits when families cannot be reached, dedicated attendance coordinator positions (even part-time), community partnerships for wraparound services, and outreach campaigns focused on the importance of consistent attendance.

5. Cost-Benefit Analysis

5.1 The Cost of Doing Nothing

Chronic absenteeism carries significant costs for districts and communities:

- Students with one year of chronic absenteeism are 7 times more likely to drop out (USED)
- A high school dropout's lifetime income is half that of a graduate
- University of Pennsylvania research found a $5,630 economic burden per chronically absent student
- Clark County, NV estimates $14.4 billion in cumulative lifetime costs across 20 graduating classes
- Chronically absent students are 12x more likely to commit serious assault and 21x more likely to commit serious property crimes
- A 3-percentage-point increase in statewide graduation rate yields ~$10 billion in social savings

5.2 TISA Funding Impact for GCS

Tennessee's TISA formula uses ADM (enrollment-based), so daily absences don't directly reduce funding. However, if absences lead to withdrawal, the district loses the full per-pupil allocation of $9,810.54 for subsequent reporting periods. For a district of ~2,500 students, losing just 25 students (1%) represents approximately $245,000 in annual revenue.

5.3 Intervention Costs: Punitive vs. Supportive

Approach	Approximate Cost	Effectiveness
Truancy court referral	$500-$2,000+ per case	Largely unsuccessful; may worsen engagement
Redesigned truancy letters	Near zero (postage)	40% more effective than standard letters
Success Mentors	$500-$1,500/student/year	~2 weeks additional attendance gained
Home visits (LEAP model)	$200-$500 per visit	7-15 percentage point attendance increase
Attendance incentives	$50-$200/student/year	Attendance improved from 82% to 92%
Community schools model	$1,000-$3,000/student/year	Sustained, comprehensive gains
Bilingual family liaison	$47,000-$72,000/year	Targeted outreach for high-need populations
Attendance officer (FT)	$50,000-$78,000/year	Justified if prevents 8-10 withdrawals

5.4 Grant Opportunities

Federal formula funds available for attendance interventions:

- Title I, Part A: Evidence-based strategies to increase attendance
- Title II, Part A: Professional development on student engagement
- Title IV, Part A: Safe, healthy learning environments
- Title IV, Part B (21st CCLC): Out-of-school time opportunities

Federal discretionary grants:

- Stronger Connections Grant (Bipartisan Safer Communities Act)
- Education Innovation and Research (EIR) Grant
- Promise Neighborhoods Grant

At the state level, 56 bills across 20 states in the 2026 legislative session address chronic absenteeism (FutureEd tracker). Tennessee-specific opportunities should be checked through TDOE.

6. Criticisms, Limitations, and Risks

6.1 The Case Against Punitive Enforcement

The strongest arguments against aggressive truancy enforcement are supported by substantial evidence. Criminalization has never been an effective response to truancy. Schools that use suspension as punishment for truancy effectively "push out" students. California's 2025 legislative changes removing jail and fine penalties reflect a national trend away from punitive models. The ACLU has published practice manuals for defending youth in truancy proceedings, indicating the seriousness of legal concerns with enforcement-heavy approaches.

6.2 Racial and Ethnic Disparities

Truancy enforcement falls disproportionately on communities of color:

Metric	Black Students	White Students
Average days missed (2018-19)	13.2 days	9.1 days
Absences marked unexcused	52.7%	29.4%

These disparities persist even after controlling for socioeconomic status. A study in AERA Open (McNeely et al., 2021) found that discrimination encoded into school absenteeism policies leads to racially minoritized students being overrepresented in the juvenile court system. Schools have significant discretion in how absences are coded, and research shows that families with resources are more likely to successfully navigate excusal processes.

6.3 Immigration Climate Risks

This is the most critical equity concern for the scenario at hand. The rescission of the "sensitive locations" policy in January 2025 has created a significant chilling effect. Approximately 9 million school-aged children (1 in 6) live in a household with at least one noncitizen adult. During earlier ICE partnership programs with local police, Hispanic children's enrollment in public schools dropped 7.3%, with elementary enrollment falling 9.4%. For a family that has traveled to Mexico, any truancy enforcement involving court systems or government agencies could amplify fears and cause permanent disengagement from the school system.

6.4 Unintended Consequences of DCS/CPS Involvement

Reporting chronic truancy as educational neglect to DCS can have serious unintended consequences. Families develop significant fear of government scrutiny that damages educational relationships. For immigrant families, DCS involvement amplifies fears of immigration consequences. The system becomes overtaxed with reports that do not reflect actual maltreatment. The typical pathway for truancy alone should be through juvenile court after the progressive plan is exhausted, not DCS, unless there are broader safety concerns.

6.5 The Excused/Unexcused Inequity

The distinction between excused and unexcused absences creates a two-tier system. One student returns with a doctor's note and has absences excused; another family cannot afford a doctor, so identical absences are coded unexcused, triggering truancy proceedings. Schools that are "bright spots" for attendance show less frequent use of unexcused labels and fewer racial/ethnic disparities. Districts should examine whether their excuse requirements create disparate impacts.

6.6 Conflicting Findings

There is tension in the evidence base between the documented academic harm of absenteeism (which argues for strong enforcement) and the documented ineffectiveness and harm of punitive enforcement (which argues for supportive approaches). The resolution is that enforcement and support are not opposites: the most effective districts maintain high expectations for attendance while deploying supportive rather than punitive interventions. The law requires progressive truancy plans precisely because it recognizes this distinction.

7. Measurable Outcomes

The following table summarizes the strength of evidence linking attendance to specific outcomes:

Outcome	Evidence Strength	Key Finding
Math achievement	Strong (causal)	Achievement "very sensitive" to attendance; 0.08 SD per SD of attendance
Reading proficiency	Strong	80%+ proficiency at 5 days absent; <20% at 10 days (Liu et al., 2022)
High school graduation	Strong	Chronically absent students 7x more likely to drop out
Third-grade reading	Strong	4x more likely to drop out if chronically absent K-1 and not reading at level by 3rd grade
Peer achievement	Moderate	Chronic absenteeism damages outcomes for peers in same classroom (Gottfried, 2019)
School accountability	Direct	Chronic absenteeism is a COSI metric in TN; F-rated schools have 2x the rate of A-rated
Adult earnings	Strong (causal)	7.3-8.2% increase in weekly income per additional year of schooling
Crime reduction	Moderate	12x assault risk, 21x property crime risk for chronically absent students
Community economic health	Moderate	$5,630 per chronically absent student in community costs

8. Bottom Line

When a student stops showing up and the family has traveled to Mexico, the district's first obligation is to follow Tennessee's progressive truancy plan: document absences, attempt contact, and when the family is reachable, hold a conference and establish an attendance contract. The law is clear that these steps must be completed before any court referral. The district should also consider whether the student meets the 10-consecutive-day withdrawal threshold under TCA 49-6-3017, which may be the cleaner administrative path if the family is unreachable and the absence is expected to be extended.

However, the legal and ethical analysis extends far beyond the statutory checklist. Federal civil rights law, particularly Plyler v. Doe and Title VI, requires that the district's actions not create a chilling effect on the family's access to education. In the current immigration enforcement climate, any action that involves courts, government agencies, or formal legal proceedings carries an elevated risk of deterring the family from re-engaging with the school system. The research is clear that punitive enforcement approaches are both ineffective at improving attendance and disproportionately harmful to immigrant families and families of color.

The recommended approach for a district like GCS is a "support first, enforce last" model. Specifically: (1) Document all contact attempts thoroughly, including dates, methods, and outcomes. (2) Engage bilingual support if needed to communicate with the family. (3) If the family is reachable, hold a conference (even by phone) to understand the situation and establish expectations for return. (4) If the family is unreachable and the absence extends past 10 consecutive days, consider administrative withdrawal with a clear re-enrollment pathway. (5) When the student returns, focus on a welcoming re-engagement plan: designate a point of contact, offer academic catch-up support, and create an attendance contract going forward. (6) Avoid any action that could be perceived as targeting the family based on national origin or immigration status. (7) If a DCS referral is being considered, ensure it is based on evidence of actual neglect beyond attendance, not simply the fact that the family traveled to another country.

The questions that remain unanswered in the research literature include: What is the optimal threshold for administrative withdrawal during extended international travel? How should districts balance TISA reporting requirements with the goal of maintaining the student-school relationship? What specific training do attendance supervisors in small districts need to handle these situations effectively? And how can districts create proactive policies that acknowledge the reality of international family travel without undermining attendance expectations for all students?

For GCS specifically, this situation may warrant reviewing the district's attendance policy to ensure it addresses extended family travel explicitly, provides guidance to principals on coding such absences, and includes language about culturally responsive outreach. A one-page protocol for "extended absence due to family travel" would help staff navigate these situations consistently and equitably.

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Appendix A: Tennessee Data

A.1 Tennessee Chronic Absenteeism Rates

Year	Chronic Absenteeism Rate	Notes
2019 (Pre-pandemic)	13%	Baseline
2021-22	20%	Post-pandemic spike
2022-23	20%	No improvement from prior year
2024-25 (K-8)	~16%	State average, improving
2024-25 (High School)	~23%	State average, still elevated

A.2 Tennessee Compulsory Attendance Statutory Thresholds

Threshold	Statute	Action Required
Start of year	TCA 49-6-3007	Written notice to all parents on attendance requirements
3 unexcused absences	TCA 49-6-3007	May serve written notice to parent
5 unexcused absences	TCA 49-6-3007/3009	Must implement Tier 2 interventions
Continued absences	TCA 49-6-3009	Tier 3 intensive intervention
After all tiers fail	TCA 49-6-3009	May refer to juvenile court (certification required)
10 consecutive unexcused	TCA 49-6-3017	Meets "withdrawal" definition
15 total unexcused/semester	TCA 49-6-3017	Also meets "withdrawal" definition
10% of instructional days	TDOE policy	Chronic absenteeism (accountability metric)

A.3 TISA Funding Impact

Metric	Value	Source
TISA base per-pupil (2025-26)	$9,810.54	TDOE TISA Guide
Funding basis	ADM (enrollment-based)	TDOE
ADM reporting periods	9 per year (~20 instructional	TDOE

	days each)	
Funding model	Prior year ADM	TISA formula
Impact of 1% enrollment loss (GCS)	~$245,000 annually	Calculated: 25 students x $9,810

A.4 Tennessee Accountability: COSI and Chronic Absenteeism

Tennessee uses chronic absenteeism as part of the COSI (Conditions of Student Improvement) accountability metric. Schools receive a score of 0-4 based on attendance for all students and subgroups. A score of 4 indicates the school is in the top 20%. Analysis by SCORE shows F-rated schools' chronic absenteeism rates are more than twice those of A-rated schools.

A.5 Juvenile Court Penalties for Truancy in Tennessee

Penalty	Amount/Duration	Notes
Fine (parent/guardian)	Up to $50	Per adjudication
Community service (parent)	Up to 5 hours	Alternative to fine
Educational neglect (parent)	Class C misdemeanor	Each day a separate offense
Student adjudication	Unruly child	Judge determines best interest